

PHP + WordPress Backend Developer Training Guide

A practical 8-week learning roadmap for a beginner intern

Purpose: This guide is your complete training path. The objective is to understand each concept, practice it, complete the assignment, and gradually become capable of handling real PHP and WordPress backend tasks.

Technology focus: PHP, MySQL basics, WordPress backend development, Custom Post Types, Meta Fields, WordPress hooks, forms, AJAX and basic plugin development.

Training rule: Do not only watch tutorials. Every topic must be followed by coding and a practical task.

Daily workflow: 1–1.5 hours learning → 1 hour practice → 3–5 hours assignment/real task → end-of-day review.

WEEK 1 — PHP Fundamentals

Weekly Goal: Understand how PHP works and write basic programming logic.

What You Must Learn

- How PHP runs on a server and generates HTML.
- PHP syntax, variables and data types.
- Strings, numbers, booleans and constants.
- Arithmetic, comparison and logical operators.
- if, else, elseif and switch.
- Indexed and associative arrays.
- for, while and foreach loops.
- Functions, parameters and return values.

Practice Exercises

- Create an age calculator.
- Create a price and discount calculator.
- Check whether a student passes or fails.
- Store doctor information in an associative array.
- Display doctors using foreach.
- Write reusable functions for GST, discount and validation.

Weekly Assignment

Doctor Directory Exercise: Create an array containing at least 10 doctors. Each doctor should have a name, specialization, experience and city. Use loops to display the information dynamically in HTML.

What You Must Submit

- All practice files.
- One Doctor Directory page.
- At least 5 small PHP programs.
- A short explanation of variables, arrays, loops and functions.

Example

```
$doctor = ["name" => "Dr. John", "experience" => 10];  
echo $doctor["name"];
```

WEEK 2 — PHP Forms, Validation and Sessions

Weekly Goal: Learn how backend applications receive and process user data.

What You Must Learn

- HTML forms and form methods.
- GET versus POST.

- Using \$_GET and \$_POST.
- Checking form submission.
- Required-field validation.
- Basic email validation.
- Error and success messages.
- Sanitizing input.
- PHP sessions.
- Basic login and logout.

Practice Exercises

- Create a contact form.
- Show errors for empty Name or Phone.
- Validate an email.
- Create a simple login page.
- Protect a dashboard with a session.
- Create logout functionality.

Weekly Assignment

Contact and Login Module: Build a contact form and a separate login/logout system. Users should not be able to open the dashboard without logging in.

What You Must Submit

- Working contact form.
- Working login page.
- Protected dashboard.
- Logout functionality.
- Proper validation.

WEEK 3 — MySQL and PHP CRUD

Weekly Goal: Understand how applications store, retrieve and manage data.

What You Must Learn

- Databases, tables, rows and columns.
- Primary keys.
- SELECT, INSERT, UPDATE and DELETE.
- WHERE, ORDER BY and LIMIT.
- Connecting PHP to MySQL.
- Fetching multiple records.
- Editing and deleting records.

- Basic search and filtering.

Practice Exercises

- Create training_db and a leads table.
- Insert records using SQL.
- Connect PHP with the database.
- Display all leads.
- Edit and delete a lead.

Weekly Assignment

Mini Project: Lead Management System

Fields: Name, Phone, Email, Service, Status and Created Date. Build Add, View, Edit and Delete pages. Add search and status filtering.

What You Must Submit

- Database SQL file.
- Complete CRUD application.
- Search/filter functionality.
- README with setup steps.

WEEK 4 — WordPress Fundamentals for Developers

Weekly Goal: Understand WordPress as a development platform.

What You Must Learn

- wp-admin, wp-content and wp-includes.
- Themes, plugins and uploads.
- functions.php.
- index.php, page.php, single.php, archive.php, header.php and footer.php.
- wp_head() and wp_footer().
- get_header() and get_footer().
- Basic template hierarchy.

Practice Exercises

- Install WordPress locally.
- Explore an existing theme.
- Create a training theme folder.
- Create and test a custom page template.

Weekly Assignment

Assignment: Create a custom page template called Clinic Services and display dynamic WordPress page content.

What You Must Submit

- Working local WordPress installation.
- Custom page template.
- Short explanation of the template hierarchy.

WEEK 5 — Theme Development and Dynamic Content

Weekly Goal: Learn how WordPress displays dynamic content.

What You Must Learn

- The WordPress Loop.
- have_posts() and the_post().
- the_title(), the_content(), the_permalink() and the_post_thumbnail().
- Featured images.
- Categories and archives.
- Basic WP_Query.
- Post IDs and slugs.

Practice Exercises

- Create a blog listing.
- Display featured images and titles.
- Create a custom query.
- Display selected posts.
- Create a simple single post layout.

Weekly Assignment

Assignment: Doctor Listing Page

Display doctor cards with image, name, qualification, experience and a link to the individual profile.

What You Must Submit

- Working listing page.
- Reusable template code.
- Correct use of WordPress Loop or WP_Query.
- Responsive output.

```
$query = new WP_Query(["post_type" => "post", "posts_per_page" => 10]);
```

WEEK 6 — CPTs, Taxonomies and Meta Fields

Weekly Goal: Learn the core skills required for custom WordPress websites.

What You Must Learn

- Custom Post Types.
- register_post_type().
- Custom taxonomies and register_taxonomy().
- Custom meta fields.
- add_meta_box().
- Saving meta values securely.
- get_post_meta() and update_post_meta().
- Displaying custom data on the frontend.

Practice Exercises

- Create a Doctors CPT.
- Create a Specialization taxonomy.
- Add Qualification and Experience fields.
- Save and display the information.

Weekly Assignment

Assignment: Doctor Management Module

Create Doctor CPT fields for qualification, experience, specialization, phone and email. Build listing and individual doctor pages.

What You Must Submit

- Doctors CPT.
- Specialization taxonomy.
- Custom meta fields.
- Frontend listing.
- Single Doctor template.

WEEK 7 — WordPress Hooks and Plugin Development

Weekly Goal: Learn how to extend WordPress without editing core files.

What You Must Learn

- Actions and `add_action()`.
- Filters and `add_filter()`.
- Plugin structure.
- Plugin headers.
- Activation/deactivation hooks.
- Custom admin menus.
- Admin settings pages.
- Saving WordPress options.
- Organizing code into includes, admin and public folders.

Practice Exercises

- Create a blank plugin.
- Activate/deactivate it.
- Add a custom admin menu.
- Create a settings form.
- Save and retrieve settings.

Weekly Assignment

Assignment: Clinic Settings Plugin

Create settings for Clinic Name, Phone, WhatsApp Number, Email and Address, then display these values on the frontend.

What You Must Submit

- Installable plugin folder.
- Admin settings page.
- Saved settings.
- Frontend output.
- Clean code structure.

WEEK 8 — WordPress Forms, Security and AJAX

Weekly Goal: Build practical interactive backend functionality.

What You Must Learn

- WordPress form processing.
- Validation and sanitization.
- Nonces.

- `sanitize_text_field()` and `sanitize_email()`.
- `wp_nonce_field()` and `wp_verify_nonce()`.
- WordPress AJAX.
- `wp_ajax_` and `wp_ajax_nopriv_`.
- JSON responses.
- JavaScript request → PHP processing → response.

Practice Exercises

- Build a callback form.
- Validate fields.
- Submit without page reload.
- Show success/error messages.
- Test invalid submissions.

Weekly Assignment

Final Project: Appointment / Callback Management System

Fields: Name, Phone, Email, Service, Preferred Date and Message.

Backend: view entries, change status, search/filter records and manage submissions. Add AJAX and basic email notification if available.

What You Must Submit

- Complete project.
- Source code.
- Installation instructions.
- Tests for valid, invalid and error cases.

Final Developer Checklist

- Can write basic PHP logic.
- Understands arrays, loops, conditions and functions.
- Can process and validate forms.
- Understands CRUD and basic MySQL.
- Understands WordPress structure and templates.
- Can create custom page templates and dynamic listings.
- Can create CPTs, taxonomies and meta fields.
- Understands actions and filters.
- Can build a basic plugin/admin page.
- Can build a secure form.
- Understands basic AJAX flow.

- Can read and debug existing code.

Code Review Rules

- Do not submit code you cannot explain.
- Use meaningful variable and function names.
- Never modify WordPress core files.
- Organize code logically.
- Validate and sanitize user input.
- Test success and failure cases.
- Before asking for help, identify the error, expected result and what you already tried.
- When using AI, understand the generated code before submitting it.

Progression Into Real Client Work

After Week 3, begin receiving small supervised tasks from real projects: add a meta field, create a shortcode, fix a PHP condition, display posts with WP_Query, create an admin page or build a small plugin feature. After Week 6, gradually assign complete modules such as a CPT, listing page, callback form or plugin functionality.

Final objective: By the end of this training, the intern should be able to take a clearly defined backend task, understand the requirement, break it into smaller steps, modify or write PHP/WordPress code, test the functionality and explain how the solution works.